

risk with local connectors. In case of MIL connectors, separate approval is required from Indian government agencies. At the same time, these connectors should be cost-effective. With imported connectors we cannot match the price of existing local MIL-grade connectors from companies like Allied and Amphenol, so the import is very less for this segment."

Talking of trends in manufacturing practices, Rajaram informs, "To avoid the complex duty structure prevalent in India, a lot of companies have set up local assemblies and bring component-level parts to do local assembly or any value-addition activities to keep the costs competitive. This has also led to many companies benefitting by implementing new ideas on value-addition activities. They say "need is the mother of invention" and many companies, while adapting global practices, cut the frills and come up with innovative products needed for the growing local market."

Growth driver is a techno-commercial factor. "Since railway and energy sectors are mainly under the government, commercial factor always comes into the picture. Of course, the reliability and proven technology are also considered as growth drivers, like in railways all products are selected on the basis of proven track record in other developed countries, as human safety is highly important here," explains Saraf.

Key players

- Allied Electronics
- Amphenol Interconnect India
- Bright Star Component
- Delphi
- Essen Deinki
- FCI OEN Connectors
- Gilard Electronics
- Harting India
- Lapp India
- Molex India
- Phoenix Contact (India)
- Protection Electromech
- Samtec
- TE Connectivity
- TEI Technologies
- Toyo Connectors & Cables
- Tyco Electronics Corporation India
- Wago & Controls (India)

Coming to connection technology, he says, "The latest development is easy cage clamp/crimp type connections. These connections have a really good impact on design in railway segment because they are free from human error. Compactness in connectors is also given due consideration in latest designs."

Boost needed

Growth in consumption definitely needs to be sustained with manufacturing units in India to ensure cost-effectiveness and better services rather than betting on imports.

"India has tremendous resources and the manufacturing industry's performance is still good despite the slowdown, hence the domestic

environment is definitely conducive to design and manufacturing," feels Saraf.

"Skill availability, infrastructure and costs are not an issue at all. Raw material availability can be an issue to some extent as the local demand did not drive the need for localisation. The government should encourage local manufacturing if we have to be successful like China. We have the numbers but lack of encouraging policies is the basic issue that needs to be addressed," adds Srinivas.

"Import duty on raw materials should be cut down. Fund allocation and foreign collaboration for setting up the industry for MIL connectors should be the agenda for the years to come," suggests Ravindra Kumar, country manager, Samtec Trading India.

Looking ahead

India needs to have a clear strategy with respect to telecom soon and encourage local players to have some local content in all consumer products sold in the country, to give a shot in the arm for the manufacturing industry.

"Telecom industry is a big bubble waiting to burst, if not for the government's policies which are in cold storage since the last telecom scam. India needs to de-regulate many of the policies and come out with a very robust telecom policy in the next six months to exploit this market. Even though the consumer market is going slow currently due to the market situation, there is an ever-growing need for innovative products in this market and the future looks very promising," says Rajaram. ●

Fund allocation and foreign collaboration for setting up the industry for MIL connectors should be the agenda for the years to come

—Ravindra Kumar, country manager, Samtec Trading India



The author is an executive editor at EFY

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